

Photoshop Intermediate: From Practitioner to Pro

Every quiz answered and explained, plus reference notes for each lab — for all eight modules. Use for grading and reteaching. Confidential instructor material.

8 modules

every quiz item + lab reference notes

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CONTENTS

MOD 1 Advanced Selection & Masking

- L01 Luminosity Masks: Select by Tone
- L02 Channel Masking & Blend-If
- L03 Select & Mask Mastery: The Hard Cutout

MOD 2 Color & Tone, Deep

- L04 Color Management & Working Spaces
- L05 Grading with Curves, Gradient Maps & LUTs
- L06 Match, Split-Tone & Soft-Proof

MOD 3 High-End Retouching

- L07 Skin & Frequency Separation
- L08 Dodge & Burn Sculpting
- L09 Eyes, Teeth & Hair: Natural Finish

MOD 4 Commercial Compositing

- L10 Match Perspective, Scale & Lens
- L11 Light, Shadows & Reflections
- L12 Atmosphere & the Unifying Grade

MOD 5 Design Systems & Type

- L13 Type Systems, Styles & Grids
- L14 Smart-Object Templates & Linked Assets
- L15 Campaign from One Master

MOD 6 Generative + Automation, Advanced

- L16 Generative for Compositing
- L17 Advanced Actions & Conditionals
- L18 Data-Driven Graphics & Scripting

MOD 7 **Multi-Shot Techniques**

- L19 Panoramas, HDR & Focus Stacking
- L20 Timeline Animation & Export

MOD 8 **Capstone**

- L21 The Brief & the Plan
- L22 Studio Session: Build It
- L23 Present & Case Study

Module 1: Answers & Lab Notes

Self-check answers with explanations, plus reference notes for each lab: what a correct result looks like, the common wrong results and why they happen, and how to check quickly while circulating.

Lessons L01–L03 (1.1–1.3)

18 quiz items

3 guided builds + 3 solo variations

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The participant workbook's self-check items use the same question numbers as this key. The lesson pages themselves don't carry quizzes; these items were written for the kit and test only what L01–L03 teach.

L01 • LUMINOSITY MASKS: SELECT BY TONE

Q1

What is a luminosity mask?

B) A selection built from the image's own brightness, saved as a mask

Why: The image paints the stencil: bright pixels become white (selected), dark pixels black (protected). Nothing is hand-painted (A), and it's tone-based, not subject detection (C).

Q2

How do you load a Lights selection?

D) Ctrl/⌘-click the RGB thumbnail in the Channels panel

Why: The composite RGB channel gives the perceived luminance, so Ctrl/⌘-clicking it loads the brighter tones as a selection. Ctrl/⌘-clicking a *layer* thumbnail loads that layer's transparency instead, which on a photo is everything.

Q3

Your luminosity-masked sky darken is spilling onto the land. What's the lesson's fix?

A) Undo the layer, reload Lights, and intersect once or twice (Ctrl/⌘ + Shift + Alt/⌥-click RGB) before adding the adjustment

Why: The Lights mask was too broad. Each intersection keeps only what both selections share, pushing the selection into the brightest tones. A hard painted line (B) brings back exactly the seam luminosity masks avoid.

Q4

After taming the sky, how do you select the dark land for the second Curves layer?

C) Reload the RGB luminosity selection, then invert it (Ctrl/⌘ + Shift + I)

Why: Inverting Lights gives Darks: the shadows become selected and the already-correct sky is black on the new mask. Intersecting Lights (B) goes the other way, into the brightest tones; no selection (D) gives an all-white mask.

Q5

Why use two luminosity-masked Curves instead of one global S-curve?

B) A single curve would brighten the sky while it lifts the land; two masked curves move highlights and shadows in opposite directions at once

Why: Straight from the lesson's "Why this beats one global Curves": the two masks let the sky go down while the land comes up, a range no single curve reaches.

Q6

Your luminosity masks look blocky and banded. What's the most likely cause and fix?

D) You're working in 8-bit; convert to 16-bit (Image ► Mode ► 16 Bits/Channel) before building the masks

Why: The lesson FAQ: the extra tonal resolution keeps new masks and adjustments smooth. Converting can't restore detail an 8-bit original never had, but it stops new banding as you edit.

LAB REFERENCE: RESCUE THE LANDSCAPE (`L01-HIGH-CONTRAST-LANDSCAPE.JPG` **OR OWN LANDSCAPE)**

A correct result looks like: `Luminosity-working.psd`, 16-bit, with the photo and two Curves layers above it. The sky Curves mask is a grayscale version of the photo (bright sky white, valley near-black, mountains mid-gray); the shadow Curves mask is its negative. The sky shows cloud shapes and a clear gradient where it was nearly white; the dark valley reveals the path, rocks and grass texture; the pale cabin keeps its brightness if the learner intersected. At 100% there's no halo along the pines or the ridgelines.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **A solid white mask, the whole photo darkened.** Curves added with no selection, or the layer thumbnail was Ctrl/Cmd-clicked in Layers (loading the whole image). Reload from the RGB channel.
- ◆ **The cabin and far hills went muddy.** The Lights mask was too broad for a strong curve. Reload and intersect once or twice.
- ◆ **A bright rim around the pines or ridgelines.** The two masks overlap and fight. Reduce one layer's opacity or re-intersect.
- ◆ **Banding in the sky gradient.** Still in 8-bit. Convert and rebuild.
- ◆ **Shadows gray and flat.** The Darks curve lifted too far; a small lift in the lower third of the curve is enough.

Quick check: Alt/Cmd-click each mask thumbnail. Two photo-like grayscale masks, one the negative of the other, means the method was right.

LAB REFERENCE: NOW YOU (`L01-STILL-LIFE-WINDOW-LIGHT.JPG` **OR OWN PORTRAIT/STILL LIFE)**

A correct result looks like: a Lights-masked (ideally intersected) Curves that lifts only the jug's highlight, lemon speculars and the cloth, with the dark wall and bottle unchanged; a Midtones-masked Curves with gentle added contrast in the mids (the jug's body and the table), nothing clipping. The Midtones mask thumbnail is gray in the midtones and dark at both extremes. The comparison note should say the luminosity mask's edge follows the light while the hand-painted one shows a band or halo somewhere.

Common wrong results: a "Midtones" mask built as Lights minus Darks (it looks like an intersected Lights mask: bright only in the highlights); the wrong modifier when subtracting (it's Ctrl/Cmd + Alt/Cmd-click on the saved channel; Ctrl/Cmd + Shift-click adds instead); a glow so strong the highlights clip to flat white.

L02 · CHANNEL MASKING & BLEND-IF

Q1

Why can a single color channel work as a mask?

A) Each of Red, Green and Blue is a full-resolution grayscale image, and a mask is just a grayscale image

Why: "Three masks you already have": every RGB image is three grayscale pictures stacked. You're shopping among them for the one with the most subject/background separation.

Q2

A bare tree against a blue sky: which channel usually gives the best separation?

C) Blue

Why: Skies are blue, so the Blue channel keeps the sky bright while the dark branches stay dark: maximum contrast. Still check all three by eye; that's the habit.

Q3

Why duplicate the winning channel before you run Levels on it?

D) The original channel is part of the photo's color; pushing it would damage the image, while the copy is a safe scratch mask

Why: "Duplicate it so you never damage the original." Note C is wrong twice over: adjustment layers cannot target any channel, which is why you use Image ► Adjustments ► Levels on the copy.

Q4

You pushed Levels hard and the finest twigs disappeared from the mask. What happened?

B) You over-pushed: the delicate twigs went white; back off until the big areas are solid and the twigs survive

Why: The lesson's "Do not over-push" warning. The mask only needs to be perfect at the edges; fix big gaps with a hard brush on the channel instead of more Levels.

Q5

You Ctrl/⌘-click your channel copy and the sky is selected, not the tree. Why, and what next?

A) White loads as the selection; invert (Ctrl/⌘ + Shift + I), click RGB, then add the layer mask on the image layer

Why: Bright = selected, and the sky is the white part of the mask. Invert to get the tree, click RGB to bring back full color, then add the layer mask from the selection.

Q6

You placed a dark texture on a white background over your scene. Which Blend-If move drops the white?

D) Drag the This Layer white slider left (Alt/⌥-drag to split it for a soft blend)

Why: "This Layer" white slider inward hides the layer's brightest pixels, so the texture's white vanishes and the scene shows through. The black slider (B) would drop the texture's darks, the part you want to keep.

LAB REFERENCE: EXTRACT A TREE (L02-BARE-TREE-SKY.JPG + L02-NEW-SKY.JPG + L02-GRUNGE-TEXTURE.JPG , OR OWN PHOTOS)

A correct result looks like: channel-working.psd , 16-bit. Channels panel: Red, Green, Blue untouched plus a **Blue copy** that is white sky over a black tree and black field. Layers: the tree photo with a layer mask (tree and ground white, sky black), l02-new-sky.jpg below it, and the grunge texture on top with This Layer's white slider pulled left (split). At 100%, the finest twigs are present over the sunset sky; the texture's white paper is gone and only its speckle and stains remain.

Common wrong results and why:

- **The photo's colors shifted (yellow cast or harsh contrast).** Levels ran on the real Blue channel or on RGB. Undo; run it on the copy only.
- **The sky kept, the tree cut out.** The selection wasn't inverted after loading. Invert the mask (Ctrl/⌘ + I on the mask).
- **Thick branches fine, fine twigs missing.** Levels over-pushed. Rebuild with a gentler push.
- **A pale blue fringe on the twigs over the orange sky.** The white point wasn't pulled far enough, so the mask is gray near twigs. A little more Levels, or a slightly darker mask edge; decontamination is L03's tool.
- **The texture layer hid the scene.** The black slider was moved, or Underlying Layer instead of This Layer.

Quick check: click the Red, Green and Blue channel eyeballs: if the original channels look like the original photo, the learner edited only the copy.

LAB REFERENCE: NOW YOU (L02-FIREWORKS-ON-BLACK.JPG OVER L02-NEW-SKY.JPG , BUSY-BACKGROUND EXTRACTION, PORTRAIT BLUE CHANNEL)

A correct result looks like: the fireworks layer with This Layer's **black** slider moved right and split, so the black sky disappears and the bursts glow over the sunset with no dark box around them; a busy-background extraction that combines a channel mask for most of the edge with hand painting or a luminosity mask for the rest; a note that the portrait's Blue channel exaggerates skin texture (the starting point Module 3 uses). The tool-choice line: blown sky above a bright shirt = luminosity (intersected Lights); leafless tree on blue sky = channel (Blue); smoke on black = Blend-If (drop darks); hair on a busy street = a combination (L03 pipeline).

Common wrong results: an unsplit black slider leaving a crunchy, stepped edge around each spark; using Screen blend mode instead (it works visually but isn't the Blend-If practice); expecting one channel to be clean against a busy background.

L03 · SELECT & MASK MASTERY: THE HARD CUTOUT

Q1

What's the order of the hard-cutout pipeline?

C) Rough in, refine, rescue, decontaminate

Why: The mantra: rough in, refine, rescue, decontaminate, in that order. Each step cleans up what the previous one couldn't; decontamination comes last because it rewrites edge pixels.

Q2

Where does the Refine Edge Brush belong?

A) Along the boundary between hair and background, never across the solid hair

Why: Dragging it across solid hair turns it translucent and mushy. Stay on the hairline, the only place it belongs.

Q3

In Select & Mask, what do Smart Radius and a slightly higher Radius do for hair?

B) They make Photoshop search a wider band around the edge for strands

Why: Edge Detection widens the zone where Photoshop looks for fine detail, and Smart Radius adapts it along the edge. Removing color (C) is Decontaminate Colors; feathering (D) is the Feather slider, which stays low for hair.

Q4

Why is Decontaminate Colors left off for the first output?

D) It comes last: it rewrites edge pixels and forces a new layer, so you run it on the final, rescued mask

Why: Decontamination rewrites edge pixels, so it can only output to a new layer or document. Running it after the channel-mask rescue means the rescued strands get cleaned too.

Q5

During the rescue, you've loaded the hair channel as a selection. What do you do next?

B) Click the layer mask thumbnail and paint white with a soft, low-opacity brush along the hairline

Why: The selection limits the paint to the strands, so white on the mask brings lost detail back. Deleting (A) destroys pixels; painting on the image thumbnail (D) paints the photo itself.

Q6

Your cutout looks fine on white but shows a halo on a dark background. What's the fix?

A) Raise the Decontaminate Colors Amount, consider a tiny inward Shift Edge, and test on the darkest background it will sit on

Why: Classic under-decontamination (lesson FAQ). The saturated or dark test background is the pressure test; always test on the darkest background the cutout will actually sit on.

LAB REFERENCE: THE HARD CUTOUT, MODULE 1 DELIVERABLE (`L03-CURLY-HAIR-PORTRAIT.JPG` **+** `L03-NEW-BACKGROUND.JPG` **, OR OWN PORTRAIT)**

A correct result looks like: `cutout-working.psd` , 16-bit, with (bottom to top) the hidden original, the new background (or the saturated test Solid Color, hidden or kept for show), the first-pass layer with its rescued mask (hidden by decontamination), and the decontaminated layer with its layer mask on top. The curls keep their bumpy outline and many of the fine flyaways survive as soft, partly transparent strands; against hot magenta or lime there's no teal halo along the curls or on the flyaways; the edge is soft, not razor-cut. The subject sits on the warm bokeh backdrop convincingly (light matching is Module 4's job and isn't required). For comparison, `labs/module-1/instructor/l03-hair-cutout-reference.png` shows the ideal edge.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Looked perfect in class, halo at home.** The original layer was visible underneath the whole time. Hide it and retest.
- ◆ **A smooth "helmet" outline, no curls or flyaways.** Smooth pushed up, Refine Edge Brush skipped, or used across the solid hair.
- ◆ **Translucent patches inside the hair.** The Refine Edge Brush dragged through the interior. Paint white on the mask to restore.
- ◆ **Teal glow on the flyaways against the test color.** Decontaminate skipped or Amount too low. Reopen Select and Mask on the final mask and raise Amount; a tiny inward Shift Edge helps.
- ◆ **Teal patches came back during the rescue.** The channel selection wasn't inverted (the backdrop was selected), or there was no selection and the brush painted the whole edge white.
- ◆ **The rescue "didn't do anything."** They painted on the image thumbnail, or on the first-pass layer after decontamination had already made a new one.

Quick check: ask the learner to toggle the saturated test layer and the hidden original. If the edge still holds with the original hidden and the test color on, it passes.

LAB REFERENCE: NOW YOU, HOMEWORK (L03-HAIR-BUSY-BACKGROUND.JPG , A NON-HUMAN SUBJECT, DARK VS LIGHT BACKGROUNDS)

A correct result looks like: on the busy-background file, the channel rescue helps where the foliage is dark behind the auburn hair but fails over the pale bokeh discs, so the learner combines it with hand painting (and names where); the non-human cutout note identifies what it stressed (a glass: transparency and reflections; a fern: many small gaps; a pet: fur like hair); a halo visible on the dark background but not the light one, fixed with more decontamination and a tiny inward Shift Edge. Going further: reopening Select and Mask on a selected layer mask lets you adjust the edge without starting over.

Common wrong results: expecting one channel to separate hair from a busy background; testing only on white; flattening instead of keeping the layer + mask.

Module 2: Answers & Lab Notes

Self-check answers with explanations, plus reference notes for each lab: what a correct result looks like, the common wrong results and why they happen, and how to check them quickly at a learner's machine.

Lessons 2.1–2.3 (L04–L06)

18 quiz items

3 guided builds + 3 solo variations

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The participant workbook's self-check items use the same question numbers as this key. The lesson pages themselves don't carry quizzes; these items were written for the kit and test only what L04–L06 teach.

L04 • COLOR MANAGEMENT & WORKING SPACES (2.1)

Q1

An image is "color poured into a container." Which two properties define that container?

B) Working space (how wide the gamut is) and bit depth (how finely each channel is divided)

Why: The lesson's mental model: the working space sets how wide the container is (which colors it can describe), and bit depth sets how finely it is divided (256 steps per channel in 8-bit, over 32,000 in 16-bit). Format, pixel size and layer count (A, C) are unrelated; the monitor (D) displays the container, it doesn't define it.

Q2

You apply the same aggressive Curves to an 8-bit and a 16-bit copy of a smooth sky. Only the 8-bit copy breaks into bands. Why?

D) The edit demands more tonal steps than 8-bit's 256 per channel; 16-bit has about 128 times more

Why: Banding is what happens when an edit demands more tonal steps than the file has. Bit depth is independent of pixel count (A) and of working space (B): you can have 8-bit ProPhoto or 16-bit sRGB. There is no such setting as C.

Q3

A learner's graded photo looks duller on Instagram than in Photoshop. What is the most likely cause?

A) The file was left in Adobe RGB or ProPhoto and never Converted to sRGB

Why: The lesson's FAQ: a wide-gamut file shown in an sRGB world. Its numbers get read as sRGB, so the colors look muted. Convert to sRGB before exporting for the web and it matches. Low quality (B) causes blockiness, not dullness; 16-bit (C) and Preserve (D) are the recommended settings.

Q4

It is time to deliver a web JPEG from your layered, 16-bit Adobe RGB master. Which is the correct move?

C) On a merged duplicate: Edit ► Convert to Profile ► sRGB, 8 Bits/Channel, then export

Why: Convert remaps the colors so they keep their appearance; Assign (A) only relabels the container and shifts every color. The lesson makes the web copy with Image ► Duplicate (Duplicate Merged Layers Only) so the master stays wide and 16-bit (B and D both damage the master).

Q5

Before any edit, the Histogram shows a tall spike slammed against the right wall. What does it tell you?

B) Highlights are clipped: detail at the bright end is lost

Why: A spike against either wall means clipped tones and lost detail. Underexposure (A) crams the data left; a flat image (C) is a narrow histogram with empty ends. A bright high-key scene (D) sits to the right but should not pile up against the wall.

Q6

Which pairing of working space and job matches the lesson's table?

D) ProPhoto RGB for heavy RAW grading and archival masters, always paired with 16-bit

Why: sRGB is for web, social and email; Adobe RGB for print (it holds cyans and greens sRGB clips); ProPhoto for heavy RAW grading and masters, and always with 16-bit or it bands. A pairs ProPhoto with the two things it must never meet: the web and 8-bit.

LAB REFERENCE: SET UP & DIAGNOSE (`L04-SMOOTH-SKY-16BIT.TIF` , `L04-HISTOGRAM-A...E.JPG` , OR OWN IMAGE)

A correct result looks like: Edit ► Color Settings reopened shows the learner's deliberate choice (Adobe RGB (1998) or sRGB), a CMYK profile, RGB policy **Preserve Embedded Profiles** and the mismatch boxes ticked. The working file's tab reads **RGB/16**. A one-sentence diagnosis is written in the workbook *before* any adjustment layer exists. Two sky windows side by side after the same hard Curves: the 8-bit copy shows distinct horizontal stripes in the upper sky at 100%, the 16-bit one a smooth gradient. `color-master.psd` is still 16-bit and wide; the exported JPEG is sRGB, 8-bit.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **No visible banding.** The Curves move was gentle, the view is zoomed out, or the "8-bit" copy was never converted (check the tab). Push the curve's ends far inward and add a second Curves.
- ◆ **Both copies band.** They converted the original to 8-bit first and duplicated afterward. Reopen the TIFF.
- ◆ **Colors jumped at export.** Assign Profile instead of Convert to Profile. Undo and Convert.
- ◆ **Master is now 8-bit sRGB.** The conversion was done on the master and saved. Re-open the practice file (or their own original) and rebuild; stress Image ► Duplicate.
- ◆ **Diagnosis names a tool, not a problem** ("add Curves"). Ask: "What's wrong in the histogram?" Aim for "The tones are crammed left and nothing is near white; it needs lifting."

How to check it fast: look at the document tab (mode, bit depth, and an asterisk or "#" for a profile mismatch in some versions), and at **Edit ► Convert to Profile:** the Source Space line names the file's current profile.

LAB REFERENCE: NOW YOU (HISTOGRAM DRILL + TWO-WAY EXPORT + TEMPLATE)

Histogram answers (also in `labs/module-2/instructor/l04-histogram-answers.txt`): **a** flat / low contrast (narrow, empty ends) · **b** high-key snow scene, correctly exposed (piled right but not against the wall: the trap) · **c** underexposed (crammed left) · **d** overexposed with clipped highlights (spike on the right wall) · **e** crushed shadows (spike on the left wall).

Two-way export: the Converted copy of `l04-lagoon-adobergb.jpg` looks like the original in the browser; the profile-stripped copy is visibly duller, most in the turquoise water, the palm fronds and the "green" and "cyan" swatches. The gray swatch barely changes. A good answer names where the shift showed most.

Template: File ► New preset saved with 16 bit and Adobe RGB (1998) or ProPhoto RGB under Advanced Options.

Common wrong results: calling **b** overexposed; stripping the profile from an sRGB copy and seeing "no difference" (the lesson warns this happens because browsers assume sRGB); a template in ProPhoto at 8-bit.

Q1

What separates grading from correcting, in the lesson's words?

C) Correcting asks "what is wrong?"; grading asks "what should it feel like?" and deliberately remaps tones to chosen colors

Why: Every grade is a remap: you decide what color each tone becomes (teal shadows, gold highlights). The lesson's pro grade barely touches exposure (B) and works with Curves, Gradient Maps and LUTs, not only Camera Raw (A). Correcting comes first to build the neutral base (D).

Q2

You want the classic teal-and-gold in Curves. In the Blue channel, what do you do?

A) Lift the shadow end and drop the highlight end

Why: Lifting the shadow end adds blue to the shadows; dropping the highlight end removes blue from the highlights, which reads as warm yellow. For a truer teal, also lift Green slightly or drop Red slightly in the shadows. B gives yellow shadows and blue highlights, the opposite look.

Q3

Your teal-to-gold Gradient Map looks garish and has flattened all the detail. What does the lesson tell you to do?

D) Set the layer to Color or Soft Light and/or drop its opacity to about 15–40%

Why: "Blend it, don't bake it." At 100% Normal a Gradient Map replaces every tone with a ramp color. Lower opacity (the recipe says about 20–30%) or a Color / Soft Light blend lends its palette to the real image underneath.

Q4

Before File ► Export ► Color Lookup Tables, why do you Shift-click each mask thumbnail and hide non-grade layers?

B) The export bakes every visible adjustment layer, and a LUT cannot store a mask

Why: A LUT is one global input-to-output color recipe; it has no idea where a mask was. The export bakes all visible adjustment layers (not just selected ones, so D is wrong), so switch off the masks and hide anything that isn't the grade, then re-enable the masks afterward.

Q5

Your LUT looks perfect on the shot you built it on but wrong on another photo. What is the most likely reason?

A) The second photo wasn't corrected to a neutral base first, and a LUT assumes a similar starting point

Why: Straight from the lesson FAQ: correct each image to a neutral base first (in the Lesson 2.1 pipeline), then apply the LUT. A LUT is a starting point, not a finisher, and it certainly travels to other images (B); that's its whole purpose.

Q6

Which order does the lesson's flowchart and build follow?

C) Correct to neutral → contrast (S-curve) → color → refine locally with masks → bottle as a LUT

Why: Correct, then grade, then bottle. Contrast is set before color (the checklist's first item), local refinement uses Module 1 masks, and the LUT is exported last, from a grade built on a neutral base.

LAB REFERENCE: GRADE & BOTTLE IT (`L05-PORTRAIT-STUDIO.JPG` **OR OWN PORTRAIT →** `L05-PIER-DUSK.JPG` **)**

A correct result looks like: `grade-working.psd`, 16-bit, with (bottom to top) the photo as Background, a neutralizing Curves or Camera Raw correction (the gray card's middle patch reads roughly equal R, G and B in the Info panel), a "contrast" Curves with a gentle S, a color Curves with the Blue shadow end lifted and highlight end dropped (optionally a small Green lift or Red drop in the shadows), a teal-to-gold Gradient Map in Color or Soft Light at about 20–30%, and at least one mask keeping the grade off the face or the highlights. A `.cube` exists, and a Color Lookup layer on the pier gives it the same teal shadows and warm highlights.

Common wrong results and why:

- **The grade looks muddy-green on the portrait.** Teal was laid over the uncorrected yellow cast. Correct to neutral first.
- **Pier looks wildly different from the portrait's look.** A stray layer (or the portrait's heavy correction) was visible at export and got baked in. Re-export with only the grade visible.
- **The LUT seems "weaker" than the portrait.** Expected when the portrait's grade relied on masks: a LUT can't store them. Discuss it; it's the lesson's point.
- **Masks still disabled in the saved master** (red X on the thumbnails). Shift-click to re-enable, save.
- **Export Color Lookup Tables unavailable or failing.** The document isn't a Background + adjustment layers structure. Rebuild it that way; meanwhile use the fallback LUT for the transfer test.

How to check it fast: toggle the Gradient Map's eye: if the change is dramatic, it's too strong. Load the learner's `.cube` onto `L05-grade-test-chart.png`: the gray ramp should turn teal at the dark end and warm at the bright end, with the mids near neutral.

LAB REFERENCE: NOW YOU (THREE LUTS, REVERSE-ENGINEERED LOOK, ONE LUT ACROSS FIVE PHOTOS)

A **correct result looks like**: three .cube files whose recipes differ in all three dimensions the journal asks about. Typical answers: **warm summer** = warm/golden highlights, slightly warm shadows, moderate contrast; **cold thriller** = cyan-blue shadows, cool neutral highlights, higher contrast, often slightly desaturated; **faded matte** = lifted black point (the RGB curve's shadow end raised), lowered contrast, often a gentle warm or green cast. Across five photos the learner should report at least one where the LUT needed per-image correction first ("a LUT is a starting point, not a finisher").

Common wrong results: three LUTs that are the same look at different strengths; a faded look built by lowering opacity instead of lifting the black point; no neutral base before applying the LUT to the five photos.

L06 · MATCH, SPLIT-TONE & SOFT-PROOF (2.3)

Q1

What is the most flattering, cinematic split-tone according to the lesson?

B) Cool shadows, warm highlights, with the mids kept roughly neutral

Why: Cool shadows and warm highlights mimic warm sunlight and cool skylight, which is how we expect the world to look. Neutral mids keep skin believable. Green/magenta (D) is the lesson's deliberately unusual pairing for the solo variation.

Q2

After split-toning, the skin looks ill. What is going on and what is the fix?

D) The color is reaching the midtones where skin lives: keep the split in the extremes, ease the amount, and mask the grade off the face if needed

Why: The lesson's FAQ answer. Skin lives in the mids, so color pushed there reads as sickly. Preserve Luminosity (C) is what the Recipes II split-tone card says to keep ticked; it stops Color Balance from shifting brightness.

Q3

You are matching a companion photo to a reference with Curves. What order does the lesson give?

A) Tones first (brightness and contrast), then black point, white point and mid color from the sampled values

Why: "Match tones before colors": a color match laid over mismatched exposure never holds. Then black point, white point and mid color, in that order. Image ► Adjustments ► Match Color (D) exists for a quick automatic pass, but hand-matching with Curves is more controllable.

Q4

Where do you read the RGB values of the points you dropped with the Color Sampler Tool?

C) The Info panel (Window ► Info)

Why: Color Sampler points report their values in the Info panel. Comparing the two images' readouts tells you which way each channel must move.

Q5

With soft-proofing on, Gamut Warning (Ctrl/⌘ + Shift + Y) grays out a neon sign. What do you do?

B) Lower the saturation there with a masked Hue/Saturation layer until the warning clears

Why: Gray means the press can't reproduce that color. Pulling those areas' saturation down (a masked Hue/Saturation) makes the print match the soft-proof. Assigning a profile (C) just shifts colors; turning off paper simulation (D) hides the problem instead of solving it.

Q6

Which delivery matches the Module 2 deliverable?

D) Keep the layered master wide + 16-bit; from merged duplicates, Convert to sRGB (8-bit JPG) for web and to the printer's profile (PDF or TIFF, or tagged RGB if the printer asks) for print

Why: One look, delivered correctly for two destinations, always from duplicates so the master stays wide and 16-bit. A, B and C each damage the master or skip a destination; B also uses Assign, which relabels instead of converting.

LAB REFERENCE: SPLIT-TONE & PROOF, THE MODULE 2 DELIVERABLE (`FINISH-WORKING.PSD` **,** `L06-COMPANION-PORTRAIT.JPG` **,** `L06-NEON-PROOF.JPG` **)**

A correct result looks like: `finish-working.psd` (still RGB/16, wide space) with a Color Balance layer whose Shadows values lean Cyan and Blue and whose Highlights lean Red and Yellow, Midtones at or near 0; skin reads warmly lit. The companion portrait has a Curves layer that lifts the cast: its gray card's middle patch in the Info panel reads close to the reference's (practice file: before correction the companion's middle patch is strongly blue, roughly R below G below B; after, the three values sit within a few levels of each other and of the reference). The proof setup names a printer profile or SWOP v2, an intent, BPC and Simulate Paper Color; any gamut warnings were handled with a masked Hue/Saturation layer. Two delivered files: an sRGB 8-bit JPEG, and a PDF or TIFF converted to the printer/CMYK profile (or tagged RGB if the printer asked for it).

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Skin looks orange or gray-green.** The Color Balance moves were made on Midtones (the default Tone). Zero Midtones, redo on Shadows and Highlights.
- ◆ **Companion "matched" but still looks different.** Channels were moved before brightness and contrast were matched, or the samplers sit on non-comparable points.
- ◆ **No gamut warning at all.** On a gently graded portrait that can be correct. Confirm proof is on (tab shows the simulated profile) and have them run Step 3 on `L06-neon-proof.jpg`: the magenta OPEN, the blue arrow, the green arc and probably parts of the orange tube gray out; brick, door and poster don't.
- ◆ **Whole-image Hue/Saturation.** The neon clears, but the whole picture goes dull. Mask it to the flagged areas.
- ◆ **Only one file delivered, or the master converted.** The deliverable is two files from duplicates; the master stays wide and 16-bit.

How to check it fast: open the two delivered files and look at the tab (RGB/8 and CMYK/8 or the printer's space); in the master, Edit ► Convert to Profile's Source Space should still show the wide working space.

LAB REFERENCE: NOW YOU (THREE-PHOTO SET, TWO SPLIT-TONES, VIVID SOFT-PROOF)

A correct result looks like: `L06-set-b-tungsten` and `L06-set-c-shade` matched to `L06-set-a-daylight`: the gray cards read neutral and alike, the linen is off-white in all three, the mug is the same blue, the lemon the same yellow. Tungsten needed Blue raised and Red lowered plus brightening; shade needed Blue lowered and a stronger black point (it is lifted and flat). The green/magenta split-tone should feel unsettling or surreal next to the cool/warm one; the learner names the emotion. The vivid-image proof entry names the areas flagged and roughly how much saturation came out.

Common wrong results: matching only by eye with a global Photo Filter; ignoring the shade frame's lifted blacks; a green/magenta split that is so strong it reads as a color cast rather than a split.

Module 3: Answers & Lab Notes

Every self-check answered and explained, reference answers for the write-in exercises on the practice files, and lab notes: what a correct result looks like, the common wrong results and why they happen, and how to check each one quickly at a learner's screen.

Lessons L07–L09 (3.1–3.3)

18 quiz items

3 hands-on labs

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The course lessons have no built-in quizzes, so the self-checks were written for this kit from each lesson's content. The workbook and this key use the same question numbers and option letters.

GRADING PORTRAIT WORK

Grade the *edit*, never the subject's appearance. Written and spoken feedback should name a technique ("the burn under the left cheekbone has a hard edge"), not a feature of the person. Permanent features (freckles, moles, lines) left in place are correct, not missed work.

L07 • SKIN & FREQUENCY SEPARATION (LESSON 3.1 • WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Q1

In frequency separation, what does the low-frequency layer hold?

B) Tone and color: the gradual shifts, patches of redness, and shading

Why: Low frequency is the slow change (cheek to shadow, redness, an uneven tan). Pores, fine hairs, and grain are high frequency (A). The neutral gray texture map (D) describes the High layer.

Q2

How far should you raise the Gaussian Blur on the Low layer?

D) Just until the pores vanish but the features stay, and note the radius

Why: The lesson's rule, often 4–8 px. Blurring the features away (A) moves them into High; a fixed number (B) ignores pore size. Flat gray (C) is what High looks like after Apply Image, not a blur target.

Q3

Your file is 16 Bits/Channel. Which Apply Image settings build the High layer from Low?

A) Blending Add, Invert ticked, Scale 2, Offset 0

Why: That is the 16-bit recipe. B is the 8-bit recipe; on a 16-bit file it won't add back to the original. There is no second radius to enter because Apply Image subtracts the blurred Low layer itself. Then set High to Linear Light.

Q4

You want to calm the redness around the nose without moving any pores. Where and how?

C) On Low, with a big soft Healing Brush (Sample: Current Layer) or a low-opacity Mixer Brush

Why: Redness is tone, so it lives on Low, and because you're only on the color layer, the texture never moves. Healing on High with All Layers (A) drags color onto the texture layer; the Background (B) isn't part of the separation; blurring High (D) erases pores.

Q5

Your High layer shows the eyes, lips, and the shape of the face, not just fine texture. What happened?

A) The blur radius on Low was too large, so real features moved into the texture layer

Why: Straight from the lesson FAQ. Rebuild with a smaller radius until High is mostly flat gray with only fine detail. The opposite symptom, a nearly blank High layer, means the radius was too small (B). Linear Light (C) is correct; bit depth (D) affects whether the stack adds back, not what lands on High.

Q6

You retouch a close beauty shot and a candid taken at arm's length. Which usually needs the larger blur radius?

D) The close beauty shot, because its pores are bigger in pixels

Why: The radius follows pore size in pixels, which is the point of the Now You. The close shot also needs far more restraint. Bit depth (C) changes the Apply Image numbers, not the radius.

EXERCISE REFERENCE: WHICH LAYER FIXES IT? (PRACTICE FILE)

On `107-portrait-retouch.jpg` (see `107-flaw-map-INSTRUCTOR.png`). **Low, tone and color (orange A-I on the map):** redness on the nose, both cheeks, and the chin; an uneven warm patch on the forehead; a muddy shadow under each eye; a sallow patch at the viewer's-left temple; a purplish patch on the viewer's-right jaw. **High, texture (red 1-10):** ten raised red blemishes across the forehead, cheeks, jaw, and chin, two of them with a pale head. **Neither (keep):** about 36 freckles across the nose and upper cheeks, the mole beside the mouth, and the two laugh lines. The flyaways, stray hairs at the temples, and the gap in the hair are texture too, but they belong to L09's hair layer; accept either column. For learners' own portraits, accept any sort that puts tone on Low and texture on High; challenge anything permanent in either column.

EXERCISE REFERENCE: THE RADIUS FOLLOWS THE PORES

Approximate radii at which the pores just vanish on the practice files: **main portrait** about 5–6 px; **close beauty shot** about 10–12 px (pores roughly twice as large in pixels); **candid at arm's length** about 2–3 px. Accept anything within a pixel or two that follows the same order. The written comparison should say the close shot needs the biggest radius *and* the most restraint; the plain soft-brush version loses the pores along with the redness.

LAB NOTES: RETOUCH THE SKIN

Correct result: the Layers panel shows the untouched Background, then a group holding **Low** (Normal, blurred) and **High** (Linear Light, gray texture) at roughly 70–85% opacity. Before any painting, the stack looked identical to the original. After: the redness, under-eye mud, sallow temple, and purplish jaw are calmer but still faintly present; the ten blemishes are gone with no soft patch or color smear; freckles, mole, and laugh lines remain; at 100% zoom the pore grain is continuous across the face. Saved as **skin-retouched.psd** with layers.

How to check fast: hide the group (the original returns), show it (calmer tone, same grain). Hide only **High** : Low should look soft and poreless. Check the title bar against the recipe they say they used.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Gray mess or shifted contrast before any painting.** The 8-bit recipe on a 16-bit file (or the reverse), Linear Light not set, or Apply Image's Layer not **Low** . Delete High, duplicate the original again, redo.
- ◆ **Features visible on High.** Blur radius too large. On the main practice file anything much above 8 px starts pulling the lids and lips onto High.
- ◆ **Color smear where a blemish was.** Healed on High with Sample: All Layers or Current & Below. Redo with Sample: Current Layer.
- ◆ **A faint pink ghost where a blemish was.** Not an error: the blemish had some tone as well as texture. Even that spot on Low.
- ◆ **Poreless, plastic skin.** Group at 100%, or heavy painting on Low that flattened the shading. Lower the group; redo Low with lighter strokes.
- ◆ **Freckles or the mole removed.** The clean sweep. They're permanent; heal them back from the Background or undo.

L08 · DODGE & BURN SCULPTING (LESSON 3.2 · WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Q1

On a 50% gray layer set to Soft Light, what does painting with black do?

C) Darkens (burns) that area and pushes that plane back

Why: In Soft Light, mid-gray is invisible; slightly darker than gray burns and slightly lighter dodges. At Flow 5–10% the black builds up as a gentle shadow, not paint (D). A describes white.

Q2

Which brush setup matches the lesson?

A) Soft round, Hardness 0, Flow 5–10%, Opacity 100%

Why: Low flow lets many passes build light gradually; Hardness 0 leaves no edge. Hard brushes and full flow (B, C) are the usual cause of streaks. The Dodge tool (D) edits pixels directly.

Q3

According to the lesson's face map, which planes do you burn?

D) The eye sockets, the sides of the nose, under the cheekbones, and under the jaw

Why: Burn what should recede. A, B, and C are all dodge zones: cheekbone tops, nose bridge and tip, forehead center, brow bone.

Q4

Why add a temporary Black & White adjustment layer while you work?

B) Color hides uneven sculpting; without it, lumps and streaks in the light become obvious

Why: It's a diagnostic view, deleted before saving. The deliverable is in color (A); Soft Light works on color images (C); the gray layer stays invisible regardless (D).

Q5

You finish sculpting and a friend can point to exactly where you dodged. What's the lesson's fix?

C) Lower the gray layer's opacity until the sculpting is felt but not seen

Why: The lesson's two rules: very low flow while painting, and lower the layer's opacity at the end. "If a client can point to your sculpting, it is too strong." Duplicating (A) or adding more (D) makes it stronger; Normal mode (B) shows solid gray.

Q6

For client work you might revise, why does the gray layer beat the Dodge and Burn tools?

A) It's non-destructive and maskable, and you can dial the whole effect up or down afterward

Why: The lesson FAQ: the tools are fine for quick throwaway edits, but they change pixels directly. B, C, and D are false.

EXERCISE REFERENCE: READ THE LIGHT FIRST (PRACTICE FILE)

On the practice portrait the window light comes from the **viewer's left**: the background is brighter on the left, the left side of the hair is lighter, the catchlights sit upper-left in each pupil, and the nose shadow falls on the viewer's right. A good plan dodges the forehead center, nose bridge, and left cheekbone most (the right cheekbone less), and burns the viewer's-right temple, under the right cheekbone, and the right jaw most.

`L08-Light-map-INSTRUCTOR.png` shows a reference map. Typical final gray-layer opacity: 40–80%; judge by the "felt, not seen" test, not the number. For the three-moods variation, accept any answer where the side-light version burns one whole side and the top-light version lifts the forehead and nose while burning under the brows, nose, and jaw.

LAB NOTES: SCULPT THE FACE

Correct result: above the L07 group (not inside it) sits one layer in Soft Light filled with 50% gray, carrying soft white and black strokes, at reduced opacity. With it on, the face has more obvious volume: cheekbones and nose bridge lifted, the sockets, sides of the nose, and hollows under the cheekbones and jaw deeper, stronger on the side away from the light. No streaks, hard edges, or blotches, even under a Black & White check. No Black & White layer left in the file. Saved as `portrait-sculpted.psd`.

How to check fast: `Alt+⌘`-click the gray layer's eye to see the map alone: it should look like soft clouds that follow the bones, not stripes. Then toggle the layer: the "off" state should look flat by comparison.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Sculpting is weaker than expected, or the group opacity changes it.** The gray layer landed inside the L07 group. Drag it out, above the group.
- ◆ **Solid gray veil.** Mode left on Normal.
- ◆ **Visible stripes.** Flow too high or a hard brush; one heavy pass instead of many light ones.
- ◆ **Paint on the face, gray layer untouched.** The photo or a layer inside the group was selected.
- ◆ **Flat or odd-looking face.** Symmetric sculpting on a face lit from one side, or dodging the shadow side. Follow the existing light.
- ◆ **Chalky highlights.** Over-dodging. Lower the layer's opacity or mask back the worst spots.

L09 · EYES, TEETH & HAIR: NATURAL FINISH (LESSON 3.3 · WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Q1

What shape does every finishing move in this lesson share?

A) Make an adjustment, hide it behind a black mask, and paint it back only where it belongs

Why: "Nothing global, everything local." B is global; C is the L07 technique; D is destructive.

Q2

What's the correct order for whitening teeth with a Hue/Saturation layer?

D) Drop Yellows saturation first, then raise Master lightness slightly

Why: "Yellow out first, brightness second." Brightening first (A) gives a bright yellow tooth; pushing lightness hard (C) gives the glowing, toothpaste-white look the lesson warns against.

Q3

Which is the lesson's method for sharpening the iris?

B) Merged copy, High Pass at about 1–3 px, blend Overlay or Soft Light, black mask painted white over the iris only

Why: The blend mode makes the gray drop out; the black mask keeps the sharpening on the iris. A and C are unmasked; D sharpens (and risks damaging) the catchlight, which the lesson calls sacred.

Q4

How do you tame flyaway hair the lesson's way?

C) On an empty layer, Clone/Heal with Sample: All Layers, short strokes along the hair's direction, leaving a few strays

Why: A dedicated layer keeps it reversible; All Layers lets the empty layer read the image below. Removing every stray (A) looks like a wig; B is destructive; D softens the whole hairline.

Q5

What's the difference between View ► Flip Horizontal and Image ► Image Rotation ► Flip Canvas Horizontal?

D) View ► Flip Horizontal flips only the view; Flip Canvas flips the pixels, so you must flip back before saving

Why: Straight from Step 4. Both are useful for the mirrored audit, but only the View command is safe to forget about.

Q6

On a real job, in what order do the Module 3 steps go?

B) Global corrections → frequency separation → dodge & burn → eyes/teeth/hair

Why: The lesson FAQ: cleaning after sculpting undoes your light; finishing before cleaning wastes effort. The pipeline order is the workflow.

EXERCISE REFERENCE: FINISHING SETTINGS (PRACTICE FILE)

On `109-portrait-sculpted.jpg` the eye whites start dull and slightly gray (about RGB 206, 198, 188) with faint pink veins, and the teeth start clearly yellow (about RGB 226, 204, 152). Reasonable results: a gentle Curves midtone lift painted into the iris and whites; High Pass 1–3 px on Overlay or Soft Light, iris only; Yellows saturation pulled down substantially and Master lightness raised only a few points. The eye whites should still read faintly gray or pink and the teeth faintly warm. Hair: 17 flyaways against the background plus two stray hairs over the temples (blue circles on the flaw map) and a thin gap in the hair on the viewer's right. Most flyaways removed, a few deliberately kept, and the gap filled along the strands' downward flow. For the magazine vs LinkedIn pair, accept any answer where the LinkedIn version is visibly lighter-handed.

LAB NOTES: FINISH THE PORTRAIT (MODULE 3 DELIVERABLE)

Correct result: on top of the L07 group and the L08 gray layer sit: a Curves layer with a black mask painted white over the irises and whites; optionally a High Pass layer (Overlay or Soft Light) with a black mask painted over the irises only; a Hue/Saturation layer (Yellows desaturated, Master lightness slightly up) with a black mask painted over the teeth, soft at the gum line; an empty-looking hair layer with the cloned strands. Catchlights intact. The whole thing passes the flip test, and toggling all Module 3 work off makes the before look tired rather than making the after look retouched. Saved as a new layered PSD so `portrait-sculpted.psd` stays as a checkpoint.

How to check fast: look at the mask thumbnails (black with small white marks), then toggle each finishing layer on its own. Each should be a small, local change you have to look for.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Whole face brighter.** The Curves mask was never inverted.
- ◆ **Glowing eyes or white-white teeth.** Curves or Master lightness pushed too far. Pull back until "clean," not "glowing."
- ◆ **Bright yellow teeth.** Lightness raised but Yellows saturation not reduced (or edited on Master instead of Yellows).
- ◆ **Gray halo around the eyes.** High Pass layer left on Normal, radius too large, or the mask spills onto lids and lashes.
- ◆ **Missing catchlight.** Cloned or masked over. Undo; it stays.
- ◆ **Double adjustment in cloned hair (brighter or grayer patches).** The hair layer sits below the Curves or Hue/Sat layer and cloned with All Layers. Move it to the top, or use the options bar's Ignore Adjustment Layers toggle.
- ◆ **Helmet hair.** Every stray removed, or long strokes across the flow.
- ◆ **Mirrored file saved.** Flip Canvas used and not flipped back.

Module 4 — Answers & Lab Notes

Every workbook self-check answered and explained, plus reference notes for each lab: what a correct result looks like, how to check it quickly, and the common wrong results and why they happen.

Lessons 10–12 (4.1–4.3)

18 quiz items

3 hands-on labs

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The participant workbook's self-checks are numbered Q1–Q6 within each lesson, so a learner's "L11 Q3" is always this key's L11 Q3. Every answer is taken from what the lesson teaches. Lab checks refer to the synthetic practice files; the geometry of the plaza is exact (horizon $y = 700$ px, vanishing point at 1260, 700), so placements can be verified with a ruler guide.

L10 • MATCH PERSPECTIVE, SCALE & LENS (4.1)

Q1

What does a photo's horizon line represent?

B) The camera's eye level, the height the lens was at, whether or not it is visible

Why: the horizon is always there, even hidden behind buildings or a hill; it is not the skyline (A). It rarely sits at the frame's center (C) unless the camera was level and centered, and it has nothing to do with focus (D).

Q2

The horizon is hidden behind buildings. How does the lesson find it?

D) Extend two receding edges until they meet, then draw a horizontal guide through that vanishing point

Why: receding parallel lines converge on a vanishing point that sits on the horizon. Guides can only be horizontal or vertical, so they cannot follow the angled edges (C); the edges are drawn with the Line or Pen tool on an empty layer. Perspective Warp (B) changes an element; it does not measure the scene.

Q3

The scene was shot at standing eye level, with people on flat ground. How do you scale a pasted person?

A) Set the feet's ground-contact point first, then scale until the horizon crosses their eyes like everyone else's

Why: the contact point fixes distance and size together; the horizon then crosses every similar-height person at the same body height. "Looks about right" (B) never does, the nearest person's pixel height (C) only works if the new figure stands at the same distance, and head-on-horizon (D) would make them shorter than everyone else.

Q4

In current Photoshop versions, what does holding **Shift** while dragging a Free Transform corner do?

C) Switches proportional scaling off

Why: Free Transform scales proportionally by default in current versions, so Shift now does the opposite of the old habit and distorts the element. Scaling from the center (B) is Alt/⌘.

Q5

Edit ► Perspective Warp is grayed out. What does the lesson say to check?

D) Turn on Use Graphics Processor in Preferences ► Performance

Why: Perspective Warp needs the graphics processor (restart if asked). It also works on one layer at a time, so select a single layer, ideally a Smart Object. Flattening (A) or rasterizing (C) would throw away the editability the lesson wants.

Q6

A telephoto headshot pasted onto a wide-angle street still looks subtly wrong after the perspective is matched. What is true?

B) Warp fixes geometry, not optics; a source shot on a focal length close to the background's is the real fix

Why: "You can't add depth a long lens removed." A wide lens exaggerates depth; a long lens compresses it. A small Lens Correction or subtle warp can nudge the feel, but a wild mismatch means choosing a better source.

LAB REFERENCE: PLACE ONE ELEMENT

A correct result: a layered `m4-key-visual.psd` with a horizon guide at $y = 700$ on the plaza (from two extended lines on their own layer), the figure placed as an embedded Smart Object or layer with its shoes touching a tile and its eyes on the guide. Height follows distance: feet at $y \approx 950 \rightarrow$ figure ≈ 270 px tall (about 19% of the 1,422 px cutout); feet at $y \approx 840 \rightarrow \approx 150$ px. Rule of thumb for this file: figure height $\approx 1.075 \times (\text{feet } y - 700)$. If the product box was used, it is a Smart Object with a Perspective Warp applied and its bottom edges follow the grout lines toward (1260, 700).

How to check fast: drag a ruler guide to 700; look at the eyes. Then zoom to the shoes: a sliver of tile between sole and grout reads as floating. Compare with `instructor/l10-plaza-answer-overlay.jpg` (ghost outlines at 8, 16 and 32 m).

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Giant in the foreground:** scaled by eye; the horizon crosses the figure at the waist. Rescale from the feet.
- ◆ **Horizon at the hills:** the learner took the visible skyline as the horizon; the true horizon is lower, where the lines meet.
- ◆ **Stretched figure:** Shift held during scaling (proportions switched off).
- ◆ **Box still "looking down":** warped on its face only; the top plane still disagrees. Add a quad on the side, and accept that a high-angle source has limits (lens/angle, not just geometry).
- ◆ **Warp can't be revised:** applied to a raster layer. Convert to Smart Object first next time.

L11 · LIGHT, SHADOWS & REFLECTIONS (4.2)

Q1

The shadows in your background have crisp, sharp edges. What does that tell you about the light?

C) It is a hard, direct source, such as the sun

Why: hardness is read from shadow edges: crisp means hard, direct light; soft means overcast or diffused (A). Color (B) and direction (D) are read separately, from the tint and from which way the shadows point.

Q2

Why are the contact and cast shadow layers set to Multiply?

A) So the ground texture shows through and the shadow darkens the floor instead of painting a flat gray blob

Why: Multiply only darkens what is underneath, keeping tiles, grain, and grout visible through the shadow. It does not blur (B) or tint (D); the tint is added deliberately.

Q3

Your cut-out uses a layer mask. How does the lesson create the cast-shadow shape?

D) Ctrl/⌘-click the mask thumbnail, fill the selection with a very dark color on a new layer below, deselect, set Multiply

Why: filling a new layer works even when the cut-out uses a mask or is a Smart Object, where Lock Transparent Pixels and a direct fill (A) would not. A Drop Shadow style (B) sits at a fixed offset and never lies on the ground in perspective.

Q4

How should a believable cast shadow change as it travels away from the object?

B) Crisp and dark near the object, softer and paler toward its end

Why: that is why the lesson blurs more with distance (Blur Gallery ► Tilt-Shift or Field Blur, or a blurred duplicate blended with a gradient mask) and fades the opacity with a gradient mask. A uniform shadow (A) is the classic "gray blob."

Q5

What color should an outdoor shadow lean toward?

A) Cool/blue, because the sky, not the sun, lights it

Why: pure black shadows (B) look cut-out. Indoors, shadows pick up the room's bounced light instead. Match the real shadows' color and depth, then usually pull back 5–10%.

Q6

Which is the lesson's reflection recipe for a glossy floor?

C) Duplicate, Flip Vertical, align the bases, lower opacity to ~25–40%, blur more with distance, mask a fade

Why: a reflection is a vertical mirror image (not horizontal, B), anchored exactly at the base. A reflection that starts a few pixels off is instantly wrong. Motion Blur or Gaussian Blur that increases downward, plus a masked fade, makes it recede.

LAB REFERENCE: LIGHT & ANCHOR

A **correct result** (on the plaza): the figure's *right* side is brighter than its left (a clipped 50% gray Soft Light layer, ↳ visible), and a clipped Color Balance or Photo Filter warms it toward the late sun. Below the figure:

Contact Shadow (Multiply, tight dark pool under the shoes, barely blurred) and **Cast Shadow** (Multiply, filled silhouette distorted onto the tiles and running **to the left**, parallel to the lamp-post and people shadows, crisp at the shoes and softer and paler at the tip, tinted cool). The plaza's existing shadows are the benchmark for darkness. The PSD is saved layered.

How to check fast: toggle the shadow layers off: the figure should instantly look pasted. Compare the cast shadow's angle with the nearest lamp-post shadow. On the glossy practice scene, zoom to 200% where the reflection meets the base: no gap, no overlap.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Shadow points right:** drawn toward the sun; the scene's own shadows weren't read first.
- ◆ **Flat gray blob:** Normal mode instead of Multiply, or one uniform Gaussian Blur and no gradient fade.
- ◆ **Shadow over the shoes:** the shadow layers sit above the element in the stack.
- ◆ **The whole plaza got lighter/warmer:** the D&B or color layer isn't clipped.
- ◆ **Too dark:** pure black at 100%; lighten to match the real shadows and tint cool.
- ◆ **Floating reflection:** bases not aligned, or Flip Horizontal used instead of Flip Vertical.

L12 · ATMOSPHERE & THE UNIFYING GRADE (4.3)

Q1

Atmospheric perspective: what happens to things as they get farther away?

D) Contrast drops, colors desaturate and shift toward the sky color, and edges soften

Why: the more air between you and an object, the more it is washed out, usually cooler and lighter. That is why horizon mountains look pale blue, and why a far element as crisp as the foreground feels pasted forward.

Q2

Where does the depth-haze layer sit in the stack?

B) Above the far elements, below the subject, its shadows, and the grade

Why: "Atmosphere goes between, grade goes on top." Haze above the grade (A) escapes it and looks pasted on; haze over the subject flattens the thing the viewer should look at.

Q3

Why does one grade over the whole stack beat grading each element separately?

C) A single set of adjustments touches every element, so they share one color identity, and you tune one dial instead of twenty

Why: shared color is shared identity; the eye reads elements under one grade as one photo. Grading each piece separately means chasing your tail forever. It has nothing to do with memory (A) or shadows (D).

Q4

What should be true of every piece before you add the unifying grade?

A) It is neutral and correct

Why: "Unify last, grade once." The grade is a mood, not a repair; if pieces don't match underneath, the grade just makes the mismatch prettier.

Q5

Which of these can serve as the unifying grade, according to the lesson?

B) A Color Lookup (LUT), a low-opacity Gradient Map, or a Curves + Color Balance group at the top

Why: the lesson says it does not matter which, as long as one set of adjustments touches the whole frame. A clipped Hue/Saturation (C) affects only the subject, the opposite of unifying.

Q6

How does the lesson finish and deliver the key visual?

D) Vignette, glow and grain, then flatten a copy, convert to sRGB, and export

Why: the layered master stays intact; only a copy is flattened. Converting to sRGB keeps the colors right on the web (Module 2). Flattening the master (A) destroys every editable layer.

LAB REFERENCE: DEPTH & GRADE (MODULE 4 DELIVERABLE)

A correct result: compare with [instructor/l12-key-visual-reference.jpg](#) . The clock tower sits on the distant hills small (roughly 200–250 px tall), with a clipped Curves lowering its contrast and lifting its blacks so it reads pale and bluish like the hills around it, not like a red sticker. A Normal-mode haze layer above the far elements and below the figure and its shadows. At the top of the stack, one grade (Color Lookup or Curves + Color Balance group) with cooler shadows and warmer highlights at reduced opacity; then a subtle vignette, a touch of glow, and grain. The master PSD stays layered; a flattened sRGB JPG is exported.

How to check fast: toggle the grade: every element should visibly "lock together" when it comes on. Squint at the tower: it should be the lowest-contrast thing in the frame apart from the hills. Open the stack: nothing above the grade except, at most, a grain layer.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Red tower still pops:** size is right but contrast wasn't lowered; haze alone won't fix it.
- ◆ **Foggy foreground:** haze painted over everything instead of just the distance.
- ◆ **Background flattened too:** the far-element Curves was clipped to the background plate (fine if the far element is its own layer, wrong if the far element is part of the plate; use a masked, unclipped Curves then).
- ◆ **Garish look:** grade at 100% opacity; pull it back until strong but not garish.
- ◆ **Only a flat file:** the master was flattened. Recover from the last layered save; reinforce "flatten a copy."

Module 5: Answers & Lab Notes

Every workbook self-check answered and explained, plus reference notes for each lab: what a correct result looks like, the common wrong results and why they happen, and how to check them quickly while circulating.

Lessons 13–15 (5.1–5.3)

18 quiz items

3 hands-on labs

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The participant workbook's self-checks are numbered Q1–Q6 within each lesson, so a learner's "L14 Q3" is always this key's L14 Q3. Every answer is taken from what the lesson teaches. Model results for two labs are in

`labs/module-5/instructor/`.

L13 • TYPE SYSTEMS, STYLES & GRIDS

Q1

With a 16 px base and a 1.25 ratio, which set of sizes does the lesson's modular scale give you?

C) 13 / 16 / 20 / 25 / 31 / 39

Why: multiply 16 by 1.25 repeatedly (20, 25, 31.25, 39.06) and divide once (12.8), rounding to whole pixels. The lesson assigns Caption 13, Body 16, Subhead 20, H2 25, H1 31, Display 39. The other options are even steps (A, B) or doubling (D), not a single ratio.

Q2

The client wants all body text one step larger across a styled layout. What makes this a single edit?

A) Editing the Body Paragraph Style once, so every instance updates

Why: a style bottles the full spec under a name; edit the style and every instance re-flows. That is "the difference between a document and a system." Retyping sizes (B) is the eyeball-each-label habit the lesson replaces; Image Size (C) scales everything, not just body.

Q3

How do you build a baseline grid in Photoshop?

D) Preferences ► Guides, Grid & Slices: Gridline Every = your body leading, Subdivisions 1

Why: Photoshop has no dedicated baseline-grid feature. The document grid set to the body leading (for example 24 px for 16 px body) is the workaround, shown with View ► Show ► Grid (Ctrl/⌘+'). New Guide Layout (A) makes columns and rows; there is no "Snap To Baseline" (B), and styles don't draw grids (C).

Q4

Snap To ► Grid is on, but your text block's baselines still don't sit on the gridlines. Why, and what do you do?

B) Snapping works on layer edges, not baselines; zoom in and align the first baseline by eye with the arrow keys

Why: the lesson is explicit that View ► Snap To ► Grid snaps a layer's edges, not its baselines. With leading equal to the grid increment (or a multiple), once the first baseline sits on a gridline every following line lands on the grid too. Auto leading (D) is usually 120% of the size and won't match the grid.

Q5

Your chosen typeface has no Bold weight, and your H1 style needs one. What does the lesson say to do?

C) Choose a different face that ships a real Bold

Why: "If a typeface ships a real Bold or Italic, use that; if it doesn't, choose a different face." Faux Bold (A) algorithmically smears the regular weight and looks cheap up close; a Stroke style (B) is the same trick by another name.

Q6

What does View ► Guides ► New Guide Layout create?

A) Columns and rows, with gutters and margins, but not a baseline grid

Why: New Guide Layout (older versions: View ► New Guide Layout) gives the horizontal division of the page. The baselines come from the document grid in Preferences. Neither creates styles (C) or artboards (D).

LAB REFERENCE: A TYPE SYSTEM

A correct result: a PSD whose Paragraph Styles panel lists one named style per role (Display, H1, H2, Subhead, Body, Caption, or similar) plus at least one Character Style (Emphasis or Link). Sizes match a written scale (13 / 16 / 20 / 25 / 31 / 39, or the copy deck's ×3 version: 39 / 48 / 60 / 75 / 93 / 117). Column guides from New Guide Layout are visible, and the document grid (Ctrl/⌘+ ') is set to the body leading (24 px, or 72 px at ×3) with Subdivisions 1. The first baseline of each text block sits on a gridline. Two families only; real OpenType on (ligatures visible in "fi"/"fl"); Faux Bold and Faux Italic off. Editing the Body style's size re-flows every body block. Compare with [labs/module-5/instructor/l13-system-layout-INSTRUCTOR.png](#) .

How to check fast: click a body text layer and look at the Paragraph Styles panel. A style name with a "+" means a local override; no name highlighted means the text isn't styled at all. Toggle the grid and zoom to 200% on one block.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **One block doesn't update when the style changes:** it was sized by hand after the style was applied (an override). Clear the override.
- ◆ **Baselines drift off the grid on line two:** leading isn't the grid increment or a multiple of it (often left on Auto).
- ◆ **Sizes like 18 / 22 / 28 / 36:** freehanded, not from the scale. Ask for the written base and ratio.
- ◆ **Type sizes look wildly wrong in the Character panel:** Units & Rulers ► Type still in points while the plan is in pixels (or vice versa).
- ◆ **A "bold" heading that looks smeared:** Faux Bold on a regular weight.
- ◆ **Four families:** the ransom note again. Back to one display, one text.

L14 · SMART-OBJECT TEMPLATES & LINKED ASSETS

Q1

You warped a Smart-Object placeholder and added clipped shadow layers. What happens to that treatment when you use Replace Contents?

B) It stays on the container and applies to the new art

Why: the container holds the treatment; the contents are the variable. Transforms, warps, filters and styles on the Smart Object carry straight over to the new art, which is what makes templates possible.

Q2

What is the key difference between an embedded and a linked Smart Object?

D) A linked one points to one file on disk that many documents can share; an embedded one is stored inside the PSD

Why: embedded is portable and self-contained, but each copy is independent (one-off protection). Linked (File ► Place Linked) is the backbone of a multi-file system: edit the one file and every document using it updates. Both scale without loss and both take Smart Filters (A, B); it is linked, not embedded, that follows the source (C).

Q3

After Replace Contents, the new design lands too big and misaligned. What's the most likely cause?

A) The new art has different pixel dimensions, and the container's transform is applied to it

Why: the container keeps its transform and applies it to whatever you swap in. Export replacement art at the placeholder's exact pixel size, or double-click the placeholder and paste the new design into its existing canvas.

Q4

Where should a mockup's shadows and highlights go?

C) On Multiply and Screen layers above the placeholder, clipped to it

Why: "Effects on the container, not the art." Painting shadows into the art (A) or inside the Smart Object (B) means every new design needs them again, or they get swapped out with the contents.

Q5

You're sending a project with linked assets to a colleague. What should you do first?

B) File ► Package, which collects the linked files with the document

Why: Package gathers all linked files so nothing breaks on another machine. Renaming the files (C) is exactly what breaks links; rasterizing or flattening (A, D) destroys the template.

Q6

You tidied your desktop and moved `Logo.png` into a new folder. What happens in the documents that link it?

D) Photoshop loses the link and the layer shows a warning until you relink it

Why: move or rename a linked file and Photoshop loses it. Right-click the layer ► Relink to File to reconnect. The lesson's discipline: keep linked assets in a project folder you don't reshuffle.

LAB REFERENCE: A REUSABLE TEMPLATE

A correct result (poster wall): above `l14-mockup-poster-wall.jpg`, a Smart Object (badge on the thumbnail) whose contents are 1200×1800 px, warped so its corners meet the blank poster's corners (about (930, 250), (1530, 290), (1522, 1172) and (940, 1216) in the 2400×1600 scene). Above it, a Multiply layer carrying the fold creases and the diagonal window-bar shadow, and a Screen layer for the lit fold ridges, both clipped (indented with a down-arrow). Replace Contents with any `...-1200x1800.png` design lands exactly on the poster with the same folds and shadow; the 1800×1200 landscape design lands distorted or misaligned, which is the intended lesson. **Tote bag:** same structure, with Warp bending the art into the fabric folds and a Multiply layer carrying the diagonal crease. **Link test:** a document with `Logo.png` placed linked (link icon on the layer) that refreshes after the source is changed or replaced with `l14-Logo-v2.png` (same 1600×600 px, now teal and gold with a coffee-bean mark).

How to check fast: ask the learner to run Replace Contents with a different design while you watch. If the treatment holds, the template works.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Shadows darken the wall around the poster:** the Multiply layer isn't clipped to the placeholder.
- ◆ **New art comes in at half size:** the placeholder was drawn at about 600×900 (the poster's on-screen size), not the art's 1200×1800 .
- ◆ **No Smart Object badge:** the rectangle was never converted, or was rasterized. Rebuild the placeholder.
- ◆ **Warp and shadows gone after a swap:** they were applied inside the Smart Object (on the art), not on the container.
- ◆ **Linked logo doesn't update:** it was placed embedded, or placed from a different copy (Downloads) than the one that was edited.
- ◆ **"Can't save as PNG with layers":** the learner added a layer to `Logo.png`. Edit its single layer directly, or swap the file in the file manager.

L15 · CAMPAIGN FROM ONE MASTER

Q1

Your campaign has a print poster, a square, a story and a banner. Which do you design first, and why?

A) The print poster, the largest, so smaller sizes scale down from it

Why: "Design at the biggest size, export down." Scaling a small master up for print softens everything. Biggest first, always.

Q2

How should the logo get onto all four artboards so one edit updates every one?

C) File ► Place Linked into each artboard (so every copy points to the same file)

Why: linked Smart Objects mean the shared art exists once and appears everywhere. Embedded copies (B) and pasted pixels (A) are independent; editing the source changes nothing. Export As (D) only renders what is already on each artboard.

Q3

What renders every artboard to its own file in one pass?

B) File ► Export ► Export As with all artboards (or File ► Export ► Artboards to Files)

Why: Export As renders each artboard to its own file, with format and scale (1×, 2×) set in one dialog. Artboards to Files is the batch alternative. Package (D) gathers linked files for handoff; it doesn't export images.

Q4

How do you adapt the poster design to the 3:1 banner?

D) Anchor the focal point first, then spread the elements horizontally around it

Why: recompose, don't squash. Keep the focal point and shared elements, and let the layout breathe differently: stack for the story, center for the square, spread for the banner. Scaling, stretching or cropping the poster (A–C) gives a banner that isn't designed for its shape.

Q5

The printer needs the poster in CMYK, but the social sizes must stay RGB. What's the right approach?

A) Keep the master RGB and make the CMYK conversion a separate, final step on an exported copy

Why: every artboard in a document shares one color mode and one resolution, so (B) is impossible, and converting the whole master (C) degrades the screen sizes. Export As does no CMYK conversion (D).

Q6

You edited and saved the linked logo file, but one artboard still shows the old version. What do you do?

C) Layer ► Smart Objects ► Update All Modified Content

Why: that is the lesson's fix when an artboard doesn't refresh on its own. Placing the logo again (A) creates a second copy and defeats the system.

LAB REFERENCE: THE CAMPAIGN (MODULE 5 DELIVERABLE)

A correct result: `campaign-master.psd` (RGB) in the project folder with four artboards: Poster 3300 × 5100, IG square 1080 × 1080, Story 1080 × 1920, Banner 1500 × 500. On each, the logo and key art are linked Smart Objects (link icons) pointing at files in the same folder; headline and subhead use the L13 Paragraph Styles (the style name shows in the panel). Each artboard is recomposed: poster stacked (key art large, headline, subhead, CTA, logo), square centered, story stacked with all text clear of the top ~250 px and bottom ~340 px bands, banner spread horizontally with key art on one side and headline plus CTA on the other. Export As has produced four files in one pass. The learner can change the linked logo (or key art), save, and show all four artboards updating, then re-export. Compare with `labs/module-5/instructor/l15-campaign-reference-INSTRUCTOR.png`.

How to check fast: open the Layers panel and expand two artboards: the same linked filename should appear in both. Then watch the one-edit proof.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Soft poster:** the poster artboard was built small and scaled up, or the key art was enlarged past 100% (the practice PNG is 2400 px wide).
- ◆ **Only some artboards update:** the logo was embedded (or pasted) on those; or the update needs Update All Modified Content.
- ◆ **Banner is a shrunken poster:** squashed, not recomposed.
- ◆ **Story text under the UI:** safe zone ignored. Drop `l15-safe-zones-story.png` on top to check, then delete it before export.
- ◆ **Type sizes differ in spirit across artboards:** styles weren't brought in; text was set by hand. Copy a styled layer in from the L13 file.
- ◆ **Missing links on reopen:** files moved or were saved outside the project folder. Relink, or Package next time.
- ◆ **Master converted to CMYK:** screen exports look dull. Undo; CMYK is for an exported copy only.

Module 6: Answers & Lab Notes

Self-check answers with explanations, plus reference notes for each lab: what a correct result looks like, the common wrong results and why they happen, and how to check quickly.

Lessons 16–18 (6.1–6.3)

18 quiz items

3 hands-on labs

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The participant workbook's self-checks use the same question numbers as this key, so a learner's "L17 Q4" is always this key's L17 Q4.

L16 • GENERATIVE FOR COMPOSITING

Q1

Which describes the right way to work with generative tools in a composite?

C) Select, prompt short or empty, pick the best variation, then mask and finish by hand

Why: The lesson's loop is generate → choose → refine, never "generate and ship." Results land on their own generative layer (not the Background), and flattening before the seams are blended throws away the variations and masks. One long prompt for a whole scene is exactly where the model flails.

Q2

Your composite is framed too tight and needs more room on both sides. What do you do?

A) Crop tool with Fill: Generative Expand, drag the edges outward, commit, Generate

Why: Generative Expand invents new canvas around the image. Free Transform and Image Size stretch or resample the existing pixels (the subject gets wider), and a whole-canvas Generative Fill selection has no empty space to fill.

Q3

A SALE sign on a post casts a shadow across the ground behind your subject. What is the best way to remove it?

D) Lasso the sign, its post, and its shadow with a little margin, empty prompt, Generate

Why: An empty prompt makes the object vanish into its surroundings; typing "remove the sign" can instead generate a sign. A selection hugging the edges leaves halos, so leave a little margin. The shadow has to go too, or a shadow with nothing casting it gives the edit away. The Eraser on the Background is destructive and leaves a hole.

Q4

What is Harmonize for?

B) Matching a placed element's light, color, and shadows to its background

Why: Harmonize (Photoshop 2025 and later) generates versions of a placed layer adjusted to the scene beneath it, on a new layer with variations. Removal is Generative Fill with an empty prompt; new canvas is Generative Expand; it is not an upscaler. Treat its output like any generative result: compare, keep, mask back.

Q5

A generated patch of sky looks slightly softer and smoother than the rest of the photo. What fixes it?

D) Add matching grain and a touch of sharpening

Why: Generated pixels often carry less fine detail than the capture. The lesson calls matching grain and sharpening "that single step" that makes a fill invisible. Regenerating doesn't reliably change detail level; lowering opacity reveals the problem underneath; flattening merges the mismatch without fixing it.

Q6

A client composite used Generative Fill. What should you check before delivering?

A) Which model produced it (Firefly or a partner model) and its terms for your account and deliverable

Why: Adobe designs its Firefly models to be commercially safe, but current versions of Generative Fill can also offer third-party partner models, which may come with different terms. "Made in Photoshop" is not a license. For documentary or journalistic work, also ask whether generative changes are allowed at all, and disclose when integrity matters.

LAB REFERENCE: HARMONIZE A COMPOSITE

Correct result: `L16-composite-working.psd` (or the learner's own composite) with the original Background untouched and, above it, separate generative layers: the expanded margins (the canvas is wider, and the plaza's buildings, wall joints, and gravel continue without obvious repeats at 100%), the removal (no SALE sign, no post, *and no orphaned shadow*), and a connective ground layer masked to the area under and left of the feet, so the figure reads as standing on the gravel. The subject layer has a harmonized version above it: warmer, lit from the right like the scene, with a mask restoring anything Harmonize damaged. Grain on the generated regions matches the scene, and one unifying grade sits on top. With the practice file, the tell-tale "before" signs are a cold, blue-faced figure lit from the left with crisp edges and no shadow.

Common wrong results: **Half a person or a repeated figure in the new margin:** the subject was visible during Generative Expand; hide it and redo. **A shadow with no sign:** the lasso missed the cast shadow. **Halo where the sign was:** selection too tight. **Mushy, low-detail ground:** the connective selection was too large, or the prompt too long. **Harmonized subject with a changed face or blurred edge:** accepted wholesale, not masked back. **Soft, "too clean" patches:** grain and sharpening not matched. **Everything on one layer:** flattened too early, so nothing can be revisited. **Subject still looks pasted** even after Harmonize: check the structure (L10 perspective and scale, L11 contact shadow); generation won't fix those.

Offline fallback version: Crop outward with Fill: Content-Aware Fill; the Remove tool or Content-Aware Fill (Output To: New Layer) for the sign and shadow; Clone Stamp and a painted contact shadow for connective tissue; the L11 hand match (clipped 50% gray Dodge & Burn plus clipped Color Balance or Photo Filter) instead of Harmonize. Grade it on the same checklist minus the variations.

How to check fast: toggle each generative layer's eye (each should change one thing), zoom to 100% along both expansion seams, and toggle the harmonized subject against the original.

L17 · ADVANCED ACTIONS & CONDITIONALS

Q1

Why record File ► Automate ► Fit Image rather than Image ► Image Size in a delivery Action?

B) Fit Image scales the long edge, so it works on landscape and portrait files alike

Why: Image Size records fixed dimensions tied to the recording file, so a portrait file comes out the wrong size. Fit Image at 2000 × 2000 px makes the longer side 2000 whatever the orientation. It doesn't resample better, doesn't sharpen, and Image Size can be recorded; it's just the wrong kind of step for mixed input.

Q2

Before recording the "Crop Wide" and "Crop Tall" helper actions, what should you change so the crops replay relative to each image?

C) Set Preferences ► Units & Rulers to Percent

Why: With rulers in Percent, crops and selections are recorded as percentages, so they play back relative to each image instead of at fixed pixel positions. A dialog toggle would stop the batch; the file you record on doesn't make a pixel crop relative; bit depth is irrelevant.

Q3

Which of these can Insert Conditional actually test?

D) Document Is Portrait

Why: Conditionals ask about the document or the active layer: orientation (landscape, portrait, square), mode (RGB, CMYK), 16 bits per channel, whether the document has layers, whether the layer is type or a Smart Object. There is no condition for pixel size, a layer's name, or a file name. Those need a script (L18).

Q4

You selected the first step of Web Delivery and inserted the conditional. What do you do next?

A) Drag it to the top of the list so the crop runs before Fit Image

Why: The conditional lands below the selected step. Left there, Fit Image runs first and the crop then shortens the long edge below 2000 px. Crop first, then Fit Image. The conditional replaces nothing, and after Save As it would crop a file that is already saved.

Q5

Which Batch settings make a run of 500 files hands-off?

C) Override Action "Save As" Commands, both Suppress options, and Log Errors To File

Why: Override sends each save to the Batch destination; Suppress File Open Options Dialogs and Suppress Color Profile Warnings remove the two common interruptions; logging errors to a file lets one bad file fail without stopping the run. Dialog toggles on, or Stop For Errors, are exactly what stops a batch halfway.

Q6

Your Action saves three sizes into three different subfolders. What should the Batch Destination be?

B) None, and let the Action's own Save As steps decide

Why: Override Action "Save As" Commands redirects every save to the single Batch destination, so all three sizes would land in one folder. With Destination None, the Action's recorded Save As steps choose the subfolders. Never point output at the source folder.

LAB REFERENCE: A DELIVERY ACTION

Correct result: an Actions panel with set **Delivery** holding **Web Delivery**, **Crop Wide**, and **Crop Tall**. Web Delivery's first step is the conditional (If Document Is Landscape → Crop Wide, else Crop Tall), followed by Fit Image (2000 × 2000 px), Unsharp Mask, Place (the watermark), Flatten Image, and Save (JPEG). **117-output/** holds eight JPEGs, each with a **2000 px long edge**, the watermark present, and the sun still round. Read the crops from the white keyline: with a wide crop on landscape files and a tall crop on portrait files, the keyline is gone from the trimmed edges and intact on the rest. File 03 (square) went through the **Else** branch, Crop Tall, because a square document is not landscape. **117-input/** is unchanged, and a droplet on the desktop processes a folder dropped onto it.

Note on Save As and JPEG: the recorded steps include **Layer ▶ Flatten Image** between Place and Save As JPG. Without it, Save As may not offer JPEG while the placed watermark layer exists (it lists formats that keep layers). A missing Flatten step is the usual cause of a batch that saves PSDs or stops at the save.

Common wrong results: **Portrait outputs the wrong size:** Image Size recorded instead of Fit Image. **Long edges under 2000 px:** the conditional sits after Fit Image. **Every file cropped the same way:** helper actions recorded identically, or the conditional's Then/Else both point at the same action. **Crops off-center or cutting the label plate on some files:** crops recorded in pixels (rulers not in Percent). **Batch paused on each file:** Unsharp Mask's dialog toggle on. **Files in the wrong folder:** Override not ticked. **A watermarked copy of the watermark in the output:** the PNG was inside the input folder. **Stray "Select" or "Move" steps:** kept recording while exploring.

How to check fast: sort **117-output/** by dimensions (every long edge 2000), then look at 02 and 03 side by side with the input versions.

L18 · DATA-DRIVEN GRAPHICS & SCRIPTING

Q1

What are the three kinds of variable in Photoshop's Variables feature?

D) Text Replacement, Pixel Replacement, and Visibility

Why: There are exactly three: swap the words in a type layer, swap the image in a pixel layer (with Fit, Fill, As Is, or Conform), and show or hide a layer. Color swaps are done with Visibility on a tint layer, not a color variable.

Q2

What actually binds a variable to a column in the CSV?

B) The variable name matching the CSV column header exactly

Why: Each variable binds to the column whose header matches its variable name. Naming the layer the same is a helpful habit, not a requirement. Column order and stack order don't bind anything, and a stray space or capital letter breaks the match.

Q3

What values should the `sale` column use to show or hide the badge?

A) `true` or `false`

Why: Visibility values must be `true` or `false`; Photoshop rejects yes/no. The broken demo CSV uses yes/no on purpose.

Q4

You want the `photo` column to list just file names like `118-ana.jpg`. What must be true?

C) The images sit in the CSV's folder and the names match exactly (otherwise use full paths)

Why: Pixel Replacement values are full file paths, or just file names when the images are in the same folder as the CSV. The images don't need to be open or PSDs, and the target layer must be a pixel layer, not a Smart Object.

Q5

You've proofed the rows. How do you render one file per row, named after each person?

D) File ► Export ► Data Sets as Files, naming by Data Set Name

Why: Data Sets as Files writes one PSD per row. Because the import ticked Use First Column For Data Set Names, "Data Set Name" is the `name` column. Batch can't read a CSV, and saving each row by hand defeats the point.

Q6

Which job genuinely needs a script rather than Variables or an Action?

B) Resize every file in a folder, skipping any whose name already starts with `web_`

Why: A per-file decision based on the file name is logic that neither Actions (no name conditions) nor Variables (same layout, changing content) can express. It is the lesson's own script challenge. Badges from a list and a show/hide badge are Variables; orientation-based cropping is an Action with a conditional.

LAB REFERENCE: A DATA-DRIVEN BATCH (MODULE 6 DELIVERABLE)

Correct result: `l18-card-template.psd` saved in `l18-data/` with layers `name` (type), `photo` (pixel layer filling the 800 × 800 window), and `sale` (the badge), bound to variables of the same names (Text Replacement, Pixel Replacement with Fit, Visibility). The data set shows six rows named Ana to Fay. The output folder holds six PSDs named by Data Set Name. In each, the name on the card matches the name tag printed inside the photo, and the SALE badge appears on **Ana, Cy, and Fay** only. Compare row 1 with `labs/module-6/instructor/l18-card-reference-ana.jpg`.

Broken-CSV demo, expected faults: `instructor/l18-cards-broken.csv` has the header `Name` (no longer matches the variable `name`), `yes / no` in the sale column, and `l18-benn.jpg` (a file that doesn't exist). The header and the yes/no values stop the import with an error message; the missing photo surfaces when you preview or export Ben's row. Fix one fault at a time and re-import to show each message.

Common wrong results: **No Pixel Replacement option:** the photo is a Smart Object. **Import error about a variable:** a header/variable-name mismatch (the Define page itself rejects invalid names, such as one with a space). **Badge never changes:** Visibility defined on the wrong layer, or the column holds yes/no. **Wrong photo on a card:** the CSV row and the file name disagree; the name tags make this visible. **Photos squashed or cropped:** method As Is or Fill with a non-square frame; Fit keeps them whole. **Files named "Data Set 1...":** File Naming left on Data Set Number, or the first-column option not ticked.

Solo variation (`l18-cards-vip.csv`): VIP ribbon visible on Ben, Eli, and Fay; tint layer visible on Cy and Eli.

Script challenge: a correct "skip" line tests the file name before opening, for example `if (files[i].name.indexOf("web_") === 0) continue;` as the first line inside the loop. If a learner's script enlarges images wildly, their rulers are probably still in Percent from L17: set Units & Rulers to Pixels and rerun on a fresh copy.

Module 7: Answers & Lab Notes

Self-check answers with explanations, plus reference notes for each lab: what a correct result looks like, the common wrong results and why they happen, and how to check. The L21 kickoff's self-check and lab notes are in the Module 8 answer key.

Lessons 19-20 (7.1-7.2)

12 quiz items

2 hands-on labs

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The participant workbook's self-checks use the same question numbers as this key, so a learner's "L20 Q3" is always this key's L20 Q3.

L19 (7.1) • PANORAMAS, HDR & FOCUS STACKING

Q1

What do panoramas, HDR, and focus stacking have in common?

B) Photoshop auto-aligns the frames, then blends the best of each

Why: All three run one engine: Auto-Align puts the frames into registration, then the blend chooses per pixel (the overlap, the well-exposed tone, or the sharpest region). Only HDR has a 32-bit option, and none of them invents detail: they choose from what the frames captured.

Q2

You are shooting a focus stack. What should change from one frame to the next?

C) The focus distance

Why: Change only the one variable the technique needs: angle for a panorama, exposure (shutter) for HDR, focus distance for a stack. Changing angle or exposure as well makes the frames harder to align and blend.

Q3

Your Photomerge result has ragged, transparent edges. Which option would have filled them for you?

D) Content Aware Fill Transparent Areas

Why: A stitched pano's edges are uneven because the frames never line up perfectly. That tick fills the gaps content-aware; the alternative is to crop them off. Vignette Removal and Geometric Distortion Correction are real Photomerge options but fix lens falloff and distortion, and Reposition is a layout, not an edge fill.

Q4

A bird flew across the window between your three bracketed shots, and the merge shows three faint birds. What do you do?

A) Tick Remove Ghosts in Merge to HDR Pro

Why: Anything that moves mid-bracket appears once per frame, faintly. Remove Ghosts takes the moving area from a single frame. Bit depth and Detail don't address movement, and Photomerge is for panoramas, not exposure brackets.

Q5

You want to keep every stop of range now and do the tone-mapping later. Which Merge to HDR Pro setting fits?

B) 32 Bit, then tone-map later in Camera Raw

Why: 16 or 8 Bit output is tone-mapped in the dialog (Local Adaptation and the other methods) and gives you a finished file now; some of the range is committed at that point. 32 Bit keeps the full range so you can decide the look later with Camera Raw.

Q6

Your focus stack is sharp in front and at the back, but a soft band runs across the middle. What is the most likely cause and fix?

D) A focus distance was skipped, so reshoot with smaller steps or mask in a sharper frame

Why: Auto-Blend can only choose from the sharp regions you captured. If no frame was sharp at that distance, no setting can create it. Reshoot with smaller focus steps, or paint a layer mask to reveal a sharper frame by hand if one exists. Seamless Tones and Colors smooths tone between regions and is recommended in the lesson.

LAB REFERENCE: MERGE THREE WAYS

Correct result (panorama): `pano-working.psd` with four frame layers, each with a Photomerge mask. The lake scene runs continuously from the red cabin (left) past the striped lighthouse to the pier and sailboat (right), roughly four times as wide as it is tall (the exact ratio depends on the projection Auto picks and the crop). No brightness steps in the sky at the joins despite the frames' deliberate exposure and vignette differences. Edges either cropped or content-aware filled and clean at 100%. Compare with `labs/module-7/instructor/l19-pano-reference.jpg` (the scene before it was "photographed"; it is a cylindrical strip, so your stitched horizon may bow a little differently).

Correct result (HDR): `hdr-working.psd` (16-bit tone-mapped, or 32-bit if the learner chose to keep range). The window shows blue sky, white clouds, green hills and trees (clipped white in the +2 frame), while the room shows the bookshelf's colored spines, the framed picture and the red armchair (nearly black in the -2 frame). One bird, not three. No bright halo around the dark window frame; the sunbeam on the floor holds texture.

Correct result (focus stack): `stack-working.psd` with four aligned layers and Auto-Blend masks. At 100%: the die's pips crisp (frame 1), the daisy's petals crisp (frame 2), the mug's "zone 3 of 4" label readable (frame 3), and the books' spine titles and the wall chart's fine print readable (frame 4). The ruler's millimeter ticks are sharp from 30 at the front to the back. Compare with `labs/module-7/instructor/l19-stack-reference.jpg` (the all-in-focus scene).

Common wrong results: **Pano has transparent corners:** Content Aware Fill Transparent Areas unticked and not cropped. **Pano doubles the lighthouse or cabin:** Blend Images Together unticked; rerun with it on. **Pano horizon strongly curved:** Auto picked a projection that bends it; try Cylindrical, or straighten with Adaptive Wide Angle. **Three ghost birds:** Remove Ghosts off. **HDR gray and flat, or glowing halos:** tone-mapping sliders overdone or underdone; aim for "believable." **Only one layer changed after Auto-Blend:** not all layers were selected. **Stack blurry everywhere with a double image:** layers not aligned (Attempt to Automatically Align unticked and Auto-Align Layers skipped). **Soft band across the table:** a frame was left out of the stack. **Merge took forever:** the learner used their own full-resolution files in class.

How to check fast: ask for the three files open side by side, then zoom to 100% on one join per file with the learner driving. If they can point to where the seam, the ghost, or the soft band would have been and show it is gone, the lab is done. The unifying grade may be homework.

If HDR Pro asked for manual EV values: the learner's copy lost its metadata. Correct entries: f/8, ISO 100, and 1/250 s, 1/60 s, 1/15 s for the `-1-minus2ev`, `-2-0ev` and `-3-plus2ev` files respectively (see `labs/module-7/README.md`). If the preview looks inside-out (window dark, room blown), the values were entered in the wrong order.

Q1

You want a smooth glide and fade, and you plan to export an MP4. Which mode do you start in?

B) The Video Timeline

Why: The Video Timeline interpolates between keyframes (smooth moves) and is the natural route to video. Frame Animation is the flip-book mode for short, loopy GIFs with exact frames. Artboards and Actions don't animate.

Q2

The badge must grow from small to full size, but its track only shows Position, Opacity, and Style. What do you do?

C) Convert the badge to a Smart Object so it gets a Transform track

Why: A normal layer's track has no scale or rotation property at all. A Smart Object gets a Transform track in place of Position, keyframes size and rotation, and re-renders crisply at every frame. Position moves a layer but can't resize it; rasterizing does the opposite of what you need.

Q3

What makes a loop seamless?

A) Returning each layer to its frame-0 state by the last frame

Why: When playback wraps from the last frame to the first, nothing should jump. Hold the finished pose for a beat, then keyframe every animated property back to its starting value by the end. Frame rate doesn't make a loop seamless, and Looping Options: Once stops it after one play.

Q4

Your motion feels robotic. Photoshop keyframes move at a constant speed. How do you fake an ease?

D) Add an extra keyframe near the end of each move with only a small change left

Why: Photoshop keyframes interpolate linearly (or Hold, for a sudden jump); there is no built-in ease curve, so there is no Ease In menu to pick. Putting most of the change early and only a little in the final stretch makes that stretch slow down. More frames per second only makes robotic motion smoother, not eased.

Q5

Where do you export a looping GIF?

B) File ► Export ► Save for Web (Legacy), GIF, Looping Options: Forever

Why: Save for Web (Legacy) (Ctrl+Alt+Shift+S / ⌘+⌥+Shift+S) exports the animation with color count, dither, and looping controls. Render Video is the MP4 door; Export As and Save As write a single still.

Q6

Your gradient-heavy loop bands badly as a GIF and weighs 4 MB. What is the better deliverable?

C) An MP4 made with Render Video (H.264)

Why: GIF is limited to 256 colors, so gradients band, and its size grows with dimensions, colors, and frames. An H.264 MP4 is smaller and full-color wherever video plays. Cutting colors makes banding worse; a PNG is a still.

LAB REFERENCE: A LOOPING ANIMATION

Correct result: `loop-working.psd` (1080 × 1080) with a Video Timeline at 24 fps and a work area of about 3 s. The badge layer is a Smart Object with Transform keyframes (small → full size, hold, back to small); the headline has Opacity (0 → 100 → 0) and Position (rises about 40 px, returns) keyframes. At least one extra near-the-end keyframe per move for the eased finish. Played on loop, nothing jumps at the wrap. Exports:

`loop.gif` set to loop Forever, ideally under about 2 MB (a reduced Image Size in Save for Web is fine), and `loop.mp4` (H.264). Compare the motion with `labs/module-7/instructor/l20-reference-loop.gif`; timing may differ, the structure should match.

Common wrong results: **Badge soft at full size:** scaled as a normal layer before converting; redo as a Smart Object. **Badge doesn't animate, it's just smaller:** scaled without the stopwatch on, so the change applied to the whole clip. **Headline pops in instead of fading:** Opacity keyframes set with Hold interpolation, or only one keyframe. **A jump at the loop point:** end state doesn't match frame 0, or the work area extends past the last keyframes (a dead second at the end reads as a freeze, then a jump). **GIF 10+ MB:** full 1080 px, 256 colors, and a long work area; shrink and trim. **MP4 letterboxed or stretched:** a 16:9 1080p size was chosen for a square design; use Document Size.

How to check fast: open the GIF in a browser tab and watch three loops; then open the Timeline and ask the learner to point at the stopwatch on each animated property. **Cinemagraph (Now You):** six frames from `l20-steam/` in Frame Animation (Make Frames From Layers), frame delays short, loop Forever; only the steam moves (the practice frames are identical outside the steam apart from JPEG compression, so a correct mask is invisible).

Module 8: Answers & Capstone Notes

Self-check answers with explanations, plus reference notes for the three capstone stages: what a solid brief, build, and case study look like, the common weak results and why they happen, and which rows of the final-assessment rubric each stage feeds.

Lessons L21–L23 (8.1–8.3)

18 quiz items

1 capstone, 3 stages

Rubric 12 rows • max 36

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK AND THE RUBRIC

The participant workbook's self-checks use the same question numbers as this key, so a learner's "L22 Q4" is always this key's L22 Q4. Rubric rows are the numbered rows of `final-assessment.html`: 1 Brief & plan · 2 Meets the brief · 3 Composition & balance · 4 Focal point & read · 5 Tonal structure · 6 Built in passes · 7 File hygiene · 8 Hero & context · 9 The story · 10 Honest process · 11 Layout & publish · 12 Present & critique. Pass = no row below 2, plus the deliverables exported at spec and a saved layered master.

L21 • THE BRIEF & THE PLAN (8.1)

Q1

Which list is the six parts of a one-page brief?

C) Objective, audience, deliverables + specs, constraints, success criteria, references/moodboard

Why: Those are the lesson's six parts. A is a layout's contents, B is tooling (downstream of the brief), and D mixes a constraint (budget, deadline) with document settings that belong under deliverables + specs.

Q2

A client writes "make it modern." What does the lesson say to do with it?

A) Pin it to something concrete: a reference image, a measurable spec, or a named constraint

Why: Specificity is the whole game: every vague adjective gets pinned. Adjectives are allowed; unpinned ones are not, because "modern" cannot be checked. A synonym is just as vague, and "you'll know it when you see it" is the infinite-revision trap.

Q3

How should the moodboard be built?

D) 6–12 references for tone, color, type, and composition, each annotated with the one thing you are taking from it

Why: Every tile earns its place with a reason, so the board guides decisions instead of decorating. One reference invites copying; an unlimited pile decides nothing; technique screenshots are the plan, not the look.

Q4

Which success criterion is written the way the lesson asks?

B) "The product name is readable on a phone-sized thumbnail."

Why: Success criteria are a checklist you could hand to someone else to grade. Anyone can test B by shrinking the image. "Feels premium," "as good as the references," and "the client will love it" can only be judged by the author or after the fact.

Q5

What makes a stretch goal safe to include in your plan?

A) It can be cut without breaking the deliverable

Why: "Scope to finish; make stretch goals cuttable." The milestones tell you whether you are on track, so you can cut stretch goals early. A stretch goal scheduled first, or one the piece depends on, is not a stretch goal.

Q6

According to the lesson, what is the commonest capstone failure?

D) Over-scoping: an ambitious idea that ends half-finished

Why: "A tightly executed simple idea beats an ambitious half-finished one every time." A simple idea is the recommended choice, and writing the brief first is the point of the lesson.

REFERENCE: A SOLID BRIEF AND PLAN (RUBRIC ROW 1)

Looks like: one page; all six parts; an objective in one sentence; an audience with a context and a moment of attention ("commuters, on a phone, for about one second"); deliverables with exact sizes, formats, color, and where they live, plus the layered master; constraints with hex values, a type family, and a date; five or so success criteria anyone could tick; 6–12 references each annotated with one takeaway; a staged plan (Figure 3's stages, irrelevant ones crossed out) with module skills, assets to source or shoot with licenses checked, two or three milestones, a finish date, and cuttable stretch goals. The partner in the Session 8 review can grade the current file against every criterion. `Labs/module-8/instructor/l21-vague-brief-fixed.txt` shows one good answer to the warm-up.

Common weak briefs: **Floating adjectives** ("bold, clean, modern") with no reference: ask for the picture that means "bold." **Author-only criteria** ("feels premium"): rewrite as a test. **Scope for a series** (a poster, six sizes, and an animation): one deliverable plus cuttable stretch goals. **A moodboard with no notes:** the board decorates instead of deciding. **No dates:** nothing tells them when to cut. **Unchecked stock:** confirm the license and credit terms now.

Brief-specific checks (quoted in the final assessment): **Key art poster:** the hero sits at the right scale for the horizon, with matching light direction, contact and cast shadows, and atmosphere; one unifying grade; the title set from a type system and readable at thumbnail size; print and screen deliverables at spec. **Product campaign:** a clean cutout at 100%; light and shadow matched to the scene; the set built from one master (artboards, linked Smart Objects) with key content inside each safe zone; the export repeatable (an Action or data set is a bonus). **Editorial portrait:** skin texture kept, dodge & burn subtle, a natural finish on eyes, teeth, and hair; a deliberate grade; layout and type from a type system; the subject's consent. **Your own:** the learner's own success criteria govern, checked for specificity before the build.

L22 · STUDIO SESSION: BUILD IT (8.2)

Q1

What does "work in passes" mean?

B) Raise the whole image a level at a time: block-in, then refine, then polish, each done across the frame

Why: Passes protect against two traps: sinking hours into a corner you later cut, and losing whole-image balance while zoomed to 300%. Finishing one corner at a time (A) is exactly what the lesson calls the amateur approach.

Q2

How does the lesson say to protect a bold experiment mid-project?

D) Save incrementally (capstone_v01, v02) at each pass and keep a flattened reference JPG of milestones

Why: Versions make a bold experiment "never a one-way door," and the reference JPGs let you compare where you were with where you are. History (and its snapshots) clears when the file closes; flattening destroys editability; a duplicated Background protects only one layer.

Q3

Which layer stack keeps every decision reversible to the end?

A) Adjustments as live layers, scaled elements as Smart Objects, filters as Smart Filters, grouped by role and color-labeled

Why: That is the lesson's layer hygiene. Merging per pass and filtering pixels directly bake decisions in; naming at the end means navigating "Layer 12 copy 3" for the whole build.

Q4

What does View ► Flip Horizontal do, and why use it?

C) Flips only the view, so composition and balance errors leap out in the mirror

Why: It changes the display, not the pixels, so there is nothing to undo. In older versions the equivalent is Image ► Image Rotation ► Flip Canvas Horizontal, which does flip the document, so flip back after. It has nothing to do with bleed or exports.

Q5

How do you run the desaturate check without harming the file?

B) A temporary Black & White adjustment layer at the very top of the stack, toggled off when done

Why: At the top it desaturates everything below, non-destructively, exposing tonal problems that color hides. Grayscale mode discards color; changing every layer's saturation is slow and destructive to undo; an exported JPG is a detour.

Q6

When is the capstone artwork actually finished?

D) When a fresh-eyes pass changes almost nothing and every brief success criterion is met

Why: "Done" is meeting the brief at a high polish, not exhaustion and not endless fiddling. If you are only moving things a pixel back and forth, you are past done: save it and present it.

REFERENCE: A WELL-BUILT CAPSTONE FILE (RUBRIC ROWS 2–7)

Looks like: a layered master plus `capstone_v01` , `v02` ... on disk and a flattened reference JPG per milestone; top-level groups by role in render order (Grade · Type & layout · Subject · Atmosphere & light · Background or similar), each named and color-labeled; adjustments as live layers, scaled elements as Smart Objects, filters as Smart Filters; a single unifying grade on top; every mask clean at 100%; the brief's success criteria ticked on the artwork; every deliverable exported at spec; end-of-pass screenshots and a true "before" saved for the case study.

How to check it: flip the view, squint at fit-to-screen, and add a Black & White layer at the top (rows 3–5); open the brief and tick the criteria against the image (row 2); scroll the progress shots for whole-frame passes (row 6); open the Layers panel and the folder of versions (row 7).

Common weak results: **One polished corner** beside rough placeholders: no passes; row 6 is 1. **Flat, unnamed stack** or effects baked into pixels: row 7 is 1; ask them to rebuild the one key edit non-destructively. **A gray deliverable:** the Black & White check layer was left on. **Two focal points competing** or a pasted element that goes dark in black and white: rows 4–5. **A criterion quietly dropped:** row 2; it belongs in the case study's reflection, not hidden. **Deliverables at the wrong size or color space:** the pass rule's "exported at spec" is not met; re-export before scoring.

L23 · PRESENT & CASE STUDY (8.3)

Q1

What is the universal case-study arc, in order?

C) Challenge → approach → process → result → reflection

Why: Every strong portfolio piece walks a reviewer through these five beats, in order. D is the capstone's workflow, not the story told about it.

Q2

What comes first on the case-study page?

A) A big, clean hero shot of the finished piece

Why: "The finished piece, big, first. Earn the scroll." Reviewers spend seconds; the brief in a line comes next, and the reflection comes last.

Q3

Which line leads with the outcome or the idea, as the lesson asks?

D) "A warm, editorial key art that reads on mobile."

Why: The lesson's own example: it beats "I used Curves and Generative Fill." Tool lists and hours spent describe effort, not the problem solved.

Q4

Why present the final piece in a mockup?

B) Context tells the reviewer what the thing is for and makes it look shipped rather than sketched

Why: An image floating on white reads as an exercise. Mockups do not excuse weak edges, and they sit alongside the before/after, not instead of it.

Q5

You laid the case study out in one document. How do you export it as a PDF?

A) File ► Save a Copy ► Photoshop PDF

Why: The lesson's Step 4. With several artboards, File ► Export ► Artboards to PDF instead. Web-sized images come from File ► Export ► Export As. Image Processor batches files; it does not make a PDF.

Q6

Part of your piece used Generative Expand. What does the lesson say?

C) Say so in the process section; you can also attach Content Credentials on export

Why: For a portfolio, disclose briefly: reviewers want to know what you made by hand and what you directed a tool to make, and many clients now ask. Using AI well is itself a skill worth showing; hiding it costs credibility.

REFERENCE: A PRESENTED AND PUBLISHED CASE STUDY (RUBRIC ROWS 8–12)

Looks like: the hero first and big; the brief in a line; an approach sentence that leads with the idea; 3–5 progress shots (the end-of-pass screenshots) and a true before/after; two or three detail crops of craft; every deliverable in a Smart-Object mockup that says what it is for (wall, feed, sleeve); one honest reflection paragraph, including any criterion that was not met; generative assistance named in the process beat. Laid out top to bottom in the learner's Module 5 type system, exported as web images and a PDF, and published. In class: a 30-second story, the hero in context, a before/after, and one specific glow and grow given to a classmate.

Common weak results: **Image only**, or the hero buried under text: row 8. **A tutorial** ("first I used Select Subject...") or a tool list: row 9; ask for the three or four decisions. **No real "before"** or a fabricated one, or undisclosed generative content: row 10 is 1. **Art pasted flat over a mockup:** no Smart Object, so no warp or shadow. **Default type, not exported, or never published:** row 11. **Opening with an apology:** coach it into the reflection beat.

CRITIQUE QUALITY: WHAT GOOD PEER FEEDBACK SOUNDS LIKE

Strong: "Your brief says the title must read on a phone thumbnail, and it does: squinting, I still see THE SALT ROAD first (glow, row 4). I wonder if the figure's shadow could fall to the right like the poles' shadows, so the light agrees (grow, row 2)." **Weak:** "I love it." (not specific) · "I'd have made it blue." (taste, not the brief) · "Something feels off." (not actionable). Coach weak feedback toward a rubric row, a pointable spot on screen, and the presenter's own success criteria.